

Foreign Giving to the University of Virginia

Lab 1 - Wrangling Data: Lukas Vrouwenvelder

Executive Summary

Between 2014 and 2020, UVA received \$22.2 million in reportable foreign gifts across 98 gifts. That's 101st out of 318 U.S. institutions by dollar total, and 10th out of 11 in a peer group of large public AAU research universities (Michigan, Berkeley, UCLA, UNC-Chapel Hill, Wisconsin, UT Austin, Georgia Tech, Ohio State, Penn State, and William & Mary). UVA trails the top peers by more than an order of magnitude, and its share of the national market has stayed under a quarter of one percent even as that market roughly doubled between 2014 and 2019. Most of its largest foreign relationships come from a handful of global-health and medical-research partnerships in Bangladesh and Tanzania. Meanwhile, China, Saudi Arabia, Germany, Canada, and Hong Kong (recognized as a unique donor by the dataset) show zero reportable gifts to UVA at all, even though each of them gave tens of millions to at least one peer institution over the same period. My recommendation is to focus attention on this gap; start with countries where UVA already has a foothold (England, Switzerland) before taking on the colder-start opportunities in China, Germany, and Saudi Arabia.

Summary of Initial Findings

Across the full dataset, which includes 318 institutions, \$16.6 billion from 2014 to 2020, giving turns out to be unevenly distributed. Qatar alone accounts for \$2.7 billion, and most of that comes from a single \$1.02 billion relationship with Cornell. The gap between the mean gift (\$588,233) and the median gift (\$94,615) shows that it's a heavily right-skewed distribution, driven by few, large gifts. UVA's own numbers look different; its \$22.2 million breaks down as \$14.8 million from 64 contracts and \$7.4 million from 34 monetary gifts. The average gift size (\$226,421) is well below the national average for either type. Giving peaked in 2016 (\$6.8 million across 31 gifts) and has fallen since, down to \$4.0 million in 2019, this is opposite to the national trend.

Against its peer group specifically, UVA comes in 10th of 11 by total dollars, ahead of only William & Mary, trailing Berkeley (\$294.5M), Michigan (\$287.3M), and UCLA (\$242.1M) by a wide margin. UVA's 98 gifts is enough to rank 57th of 318 institutions by count, but that activity hasn't translated into dollar totals that are competitive with its peers.

Strategy: Where to Source New Funding

To compare UVA's giving to its peers country by country, a comparison was made between what UVA received from each country, and what the peer average received from that same country. Some specific, sizable gaps show up right away: England is the largest, as UVA received \$2.0 million against a \$16.9 million peer average. Japan is similar, with \$266,000 for UVA versus \$12.0 million on average. Five countries (China, Saudi Arabia, Germany, Canada, and Hong Kong) show zero reportable gifts to UVA, despite donations to peer institutions well into eight figures. Berkeley alone received \$35.9 million from China and \$28.9 million from Germany. UCLA drew \$54.0 million from England.

Perhaps the most sensible way to prioritize this is to focus on existing donors by building the England and Switzerland relationships before taking on non-donors like China and Germany, and within that model, focus attention on the hospital and research-institute-based funding that seemingly dominates UVA's current donation sources. That said, the five non-donors represent a sizable opportunity.

Conclusion: UVA's Prospects for Increasing Foreign Giving

UVA's foreign-giving numbers are narrow, and they haven't kept pace with a national market that roughly doubled over this period. UVA is also well behind its own peer group in dollar terms. Considering this analysis, it's reasonable to conclude that UVA stands to improve foreign giving if it's to keep pace with peer institutions. Specifically, the short, ranked list of specific countries, several of which already give tens of millions to comparable universities, where UVA currently has little or no presence, represents an actionable opportunity to secure additional funding. Even closing a fraction of the England, Japan, and China gaps would meaningfully change where UVA stands among its peers.